to respond to China's moves in the South China Sea, stretching over both the Obama and Trump administrations. The positions ranged from a legalistic stance based on accepted international law to calls for limited military activity, including freedom of navigation operations (ambiguously twinned with claims of "innocent passage")[7] by US Navy ships and occasionally flyovers by US planes around China's claimed territories. Plans for multination maritime patrols in the South China Sea were discussed while observers totaled up the acreage of China's reclaimed islands and observed the ongoing construction of military-use facilities on the former reefs.[8]

Yet this intense interest in the South China Sea, however justified, occluded a larger picture of the strategic environment in East Asia, even as it revealed fears about America's position within it. There often seems to be a serial quality to Washington's concern and response. It traditionally appears to prefer focusing, or is able to focus, on only one subregion at a time. Thus, at a given moment, the Spratlys occupy its analysis while it ignores the Paracels in the same sea. Only a few years ago, the Obama administration concentrated on the growing risk of a clash between Japan and China over the Senkaku Islands (Ch. Diaoyutai) in the East China Sea while doing little about the South China Sea. Washington is thus taken by surprise each time a new challenge to the status quo appears. Meanwhile, the Chinese steadily attempt to encroach throughout the Indo-Pacific, linking maritime and land trade routes under the umbrella of the One Belt One Road (OBOR) initiative, while expanding the operational capabilities of the PLA Navy and Air Force in waters and skies far from China's shores.

Chinese strategy in the region has long been guided by the desire to control the maritime and air space within the so-called first- and second-island chains. These "chains" encompass firstly the East and South China Seas, linking up with Beijing's "nine-dash line" claim to the South China Sea. The second island chain is far broader in scope, encompassing Japanese territory and reaching far into the western Pacific, all the way to the US territory of Guam in the Marianas.